

Everything you can do in NovaHR

A start-to-finish guide to running your people and payroll on NovaHR, built for South African employers. Follow it in order to set up, or jump to any section when you need it.

Applies to

NovaHR (all plans)

Region

South Africa · SARS & BCEA

Roles covered

HR admin, Manager, Employee, Executive

1 Getting started

Create your workspace, understand what each person sees, and find your way around.

Create your company

NovaHR is self-service. From the sign-up page you create your **workspace** (your company), your own **HR administrator** account, and a first scheduled pay run in one step. Your workspace starts on a free trial; you can add a plan later under **Billing** (see section 12).

1

Go to the sign-up page and enter your company name, your name, work email and a password.

2

Confirm your email address from the message we send you.

3

You land on the **Dashboard** with a **Getting started** checklist that walks you through the first five tasks.

The dashboard and how to move around

The dashboard is your home base. The left rail is your main navigation and it changes with your role, so people only see what they are allowed to use.

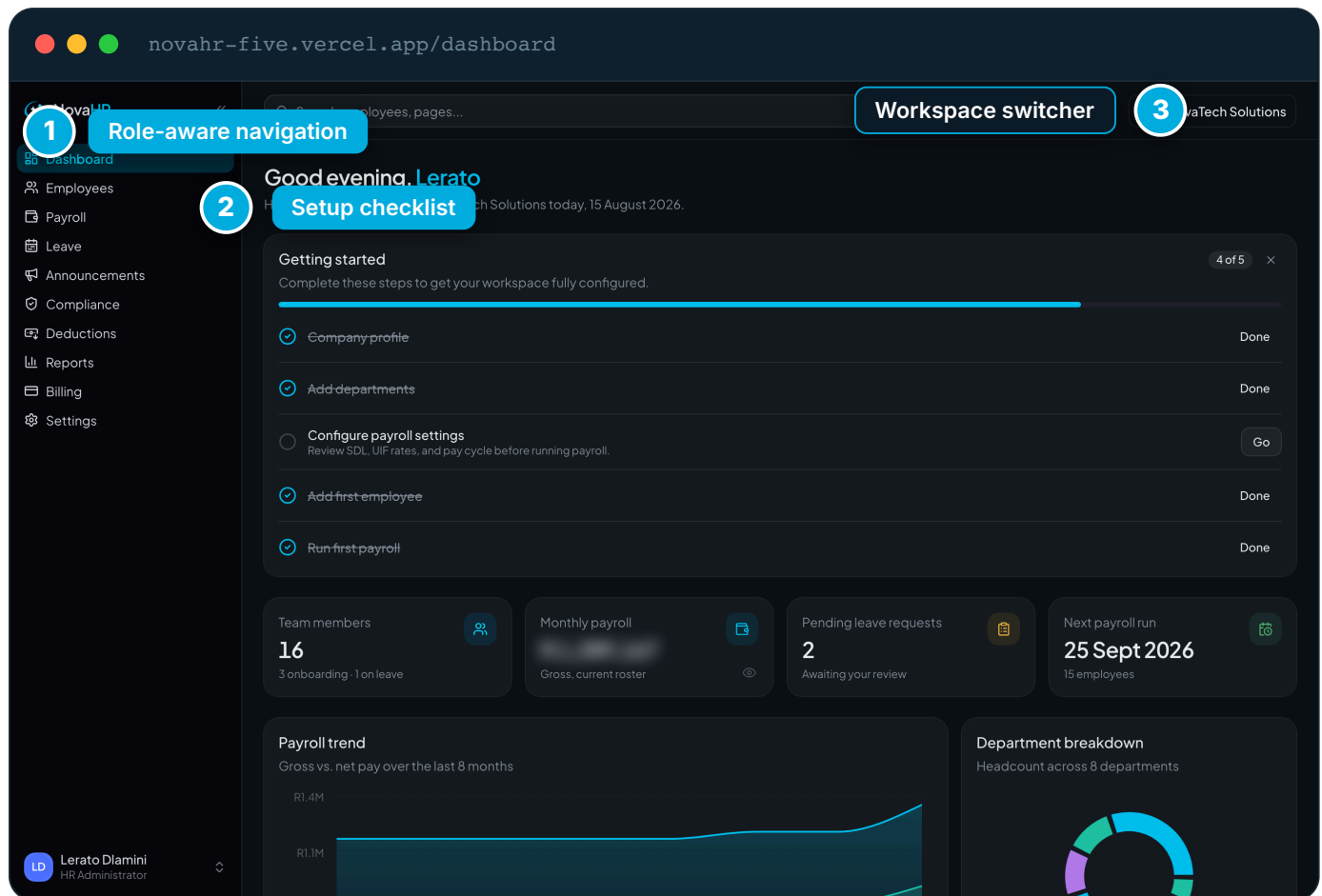


Figure 1.1: The HR administrator dashboard. **1** The left rail adapts to your role. **2** The getting-started checklist. **3** Switch between companies you belong to from the top-right.

Who sees what: the four roles

Every person in NovaHR has one role per workspace. Navigation and data adapt automatically.

ROLE	BEST FOR	CAN DO
HR administrator	People and payroll owners	Full access: employees, payroll, leave, compliance, reports, settings, billing.
Manager	Team leads	Their own record plus their direct reports: approve leave, run reviews, view their team.
Employee	Everyone	Self-service: profile, payslips, tax certificates, leave requests, documents.
Executive	Owners and exco	Read-only oversight across the company: dashboards, reports, headcount and cost.

Your profile and two-factor authentication

Open **your name** at the bottom of the left rail, then **Account**, to edit your name, job title and avatar colour, change your password, or turn on two-factor authentication.

1

On the **Account** page, find **Two-factor authentication** and choose **Enable**.

2

Scan the QR code with an authenticator app (or type the secret in by hand).

3

Enter the six-digit code to confirm. You can turn it off again from the same place.

i **Tip.** If you belong to more than one company, use the **workspace switcher** at the top right to move between them. Your role can be different in each one.

2 Setting up your company

Configure NovaHR once so that payroll, leave and compliance behave the way your company works. Everything here lives under **Settings**.

HR administrator

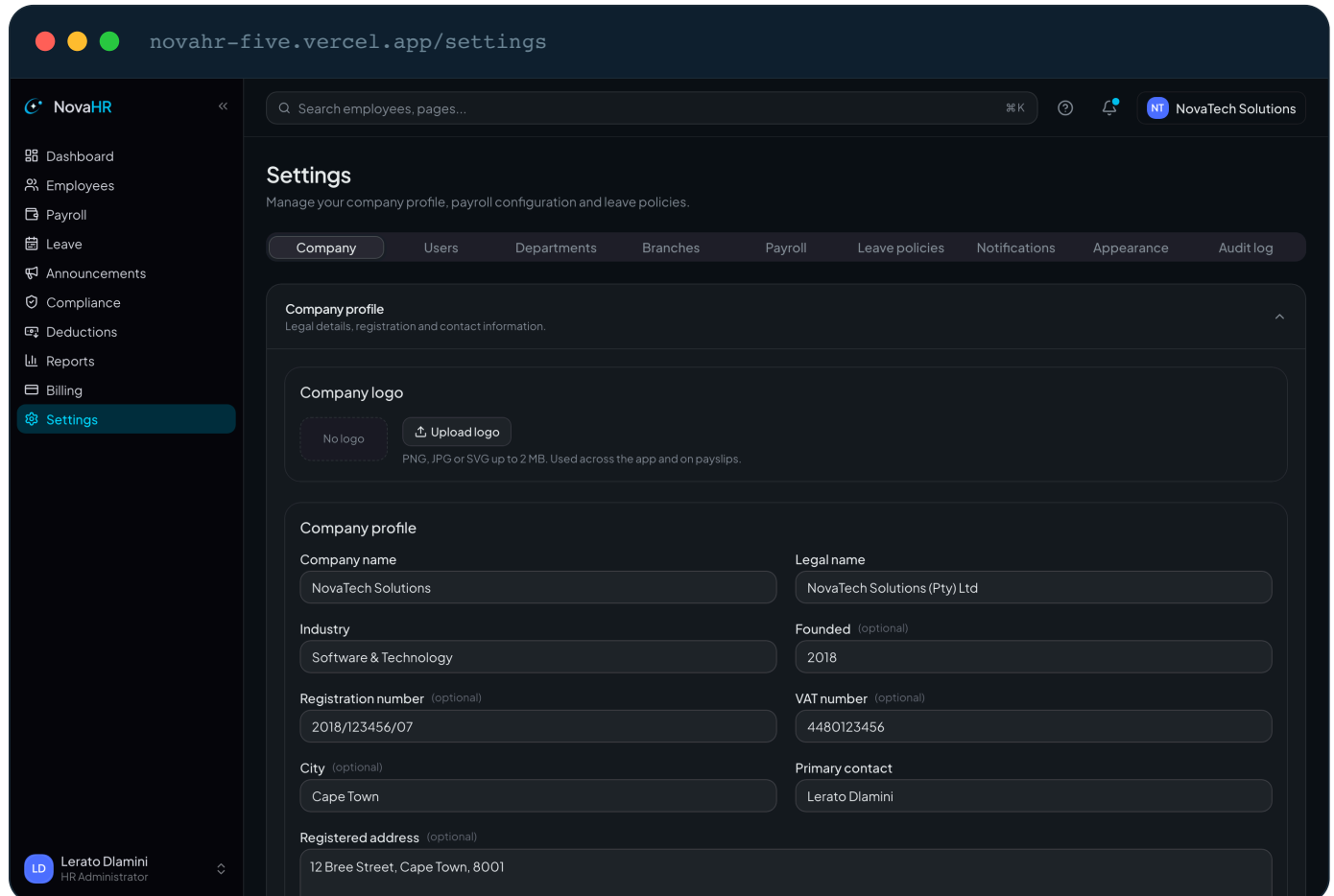


Figure 2.1: The Settings area, where company, structure, leave, payroll and statutory details are configured.

Company profile and structure

- **Company profile:** legal name, trading name, contact details and logo.
- **Branches, departments and cost centres:** build your structure so employees, pay groups and reports can be scoped to a branch or department.
- **Position catalogue:** job titles that suggest themselves when you add or edit an employee.

Statutory references

Capture your **PAYE, UIF and SDL reference numbers** and confirm the tax tables and rates. NovaHR ships with the current South African tax tables already loaded and validated.

 **Do not edit tax tables or rates casually.** They are pre-loaded and validated against SARS. Change them only on advice from your accountant or when SARS publishes new tables.

Leave policy

Set how leave works for your company. NovaHR follows the Basic Conditions of Employment Act (BCEA) out of the box, and every value is configurable.

- **Entitlement days** per leave type (annual, sick, family responsibility, and so on).
- **Annual leave method:** accrue monthly or grant upfront, with **carryover** and a carryover **cap**.
- **Sick-note threshold:** the number of days after which a medical certificate is required.
- **Employer-paid family leave:** maternity, parental, adoption and commissioning leave default to unpaid by the employer (claimed from UIF). Toggle any of them to paid if you offer it as a benefit.
- **Public holidays** and a **birthday calendar**, including custom company holidays.

Pay frequencies and pay groups

Add the pay frequencies you use (monthly, fortnightly, weekly). Later you can scope a pay run to a **branch** and a **frequency** so that, for example, weekly and monthly staff run separately. See section 6.

Payslip studio

Brand your payslips with your logo, colours and layout so the PDFs your team downloads match your company.

 **Where to start.** Complete the **Getting started** checklist on the dashboard. It links straight to the company profile, departments, payroll settings, your first employee and your first pay run.

3 Adding & managing employees

Add one employee at a time with the guided wizard, then keep a rich, South-African-aware record for each person.

HR administrator

Manager (own team)

Add an employee

Open **Employees** and choose **Add employee**. The wizard has four steps, each validated before you continue.

Figure 3.1: The add-employee wizard. Steps **1** Personal details, **2** Role & employment, **3** Compensation, **4** Review & confirm. **5** A South African ID number auto-derives date of birth and gender, both still editable.

- 1 Personal details.** Name, contact, and identity. Enter a **South African ID** (date of birth and gender fill in automatically) or switch to **Passport** to capture nationality and date of birth. Choose from South-African-context dropdowns for gender, marital status and qualifications.
- 2 Role & employment.** Job title, department, branch, reporting line, employment type (full-time, part-time, fixed-term, temporary, casual, learnership, internship) and start date. Probation defaults to three months and is editable.
- 3 Compensation.** Salary, pay frequency, allowances and banking details.

4 **Review & confirm.** Check everything, then create the employee and start their onboarding checklist.

The employee record

Open any person from the **Employees** list to see their full record.

The screenshot shows the NovaHR web application interface. The browser address bar displays `novahr-five.vercel.app/employees`. The left sidebar contains a navigation menu with items: Dashboard, Employees (selected), Payroll, Leave, Announcements, Compliance, Deductions, Reports, Billing, and Settings. The main content area is titled "Employees" and includes a subtitle "Manage your team's profiles, roles and onboarding progress." Above the employee list, there are summary cards for "16 Total employees", "12 Active", "3 Onboarding", and "8 Departments". A search bar is present with the placeholder "Search employees, pages...". A callout box highlights the "Search, filter, import & export" functionality. Below the summary cards, there are filters for "All departments", "Active", and a checkbox for "Show terminated", along with an "Export" button. The employee list table has columns: Employee, Department, Status, Type, Location, Annual salary, and Onboarding. The table lists 10 employees, all with "Active" status and "Full-time (permanent)" type, located in "Cape Town, HQ".

Employee	Department	Status	Type	Location	Annual salary	Onboarding
Aisha Patel Senior Software Engineer NT-0003	Engineering	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 950,000	-
Buhle Khumalo Account Executive NT-0009	Sales	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 580,000	-
Craig Adams Head of Sales NT-0008	Sales	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 1,500,000	-
Johan Pretorius Software Engineer NT-0004	Engineering	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 650,000	-
Kabelo Modise Head of Customer Success NT-0013	Customer Success	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 1,050,000	-
Lerato Dlamini Chief People Officer NT-0001	People & Culture	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 1,400,000	-
Michelle van Wyk Head of Marketing NT-0010	Marketing	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 1,100,000	-
Ryan Govender Head of Product NT-0006	Product	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 1,400,000	-
Thabo Nkosi VP of Engineering NT-0002	Engineering	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 1,650,000	-
Tumi Sithole Payroll Administrator NT-0012	Finance	Active	Full-time (permanent)	Cape Town, HQ	R 420,000	-

Figure 3.2: The employee directory with search and filters by department, branch and status. 1 Import and export live here (section 4).

Each record holds far more than the basics:

AREA	WHAT IT CAPTURES
Personal & identity	Contact, residential address, next-of-kin, emergency contact, tax number, SA ID or passport.
Demographics	Employment-equity fields: race, gender, occupational level, foreign national, disability.
Qualifications & skills	Structured qualifications (type, institution, year, expiry), skills, languages, and your own custom fields.
Probation	Default three-month probation with an editable end date and confirm-or-extend reminders.
History timeline	Promotions, transfers and salary changes captured automatically when you edit the record.
Documents vault	Private, per-employee files with categories, expiry dates and version history (section 8).

Directory and organisation chart

The **Employees** area includes a searchable directory and a clickable **organisation chart** built from reporting lines, so you can see the whole company at a glance.

4 Bulk onboarding (CSV import)

Moving a whole team onto NovaHR? Import everyone at once from a spreadsheet instead of adding people one by one.

HR administrator

- 1 Go to **Employees** and choose **Import** (top right of the list, see Figure 3.2).
- 2 **Download the CSV template.** It has a column for every field NovaHR expects, in the right order.
- 3 Fill in one row per employee in Excel, Numbers or Google Sheets, then save as CSV.
- 4 **Upload the file.** NovaHR validates every row and shows you exactly which cells need attention before anything is created.
- 5 Fix any flagged rows in your spreadsheet and re-upload, then **confirm** to create all the employees at once.

✓ **Good to know.** Validation runs before any record is created, so a few bad rows never leave your team half-imported. The errors name the row and the field so they are quick to fix.

i **Exporting.** You can export your employees to CSV or Excel at any time from the same menu. Salary columns are only included for HR and executive roles.

5 Leave management

Request, approve and track leave against a South African statutory framework, with balances and a calendar everyone can see.

Employee (request)

Manager (approve)

HR administrator

Request leave (employee)

- 1 Open **Leave** and choose **New request**.
- 2 Pick the **leave type** (annual, sick, family responsibility, maternity, parental, adoption, commissioning, study or unpaid).
- 3 Select your dates on the day-picker. You can choose **half-days** and non-contiguous dates; weekends and public holidays are handled for you.
- 4 Add a reason or note if needed and **submit**. NovaHR checks your balance and warns you before you go negative.

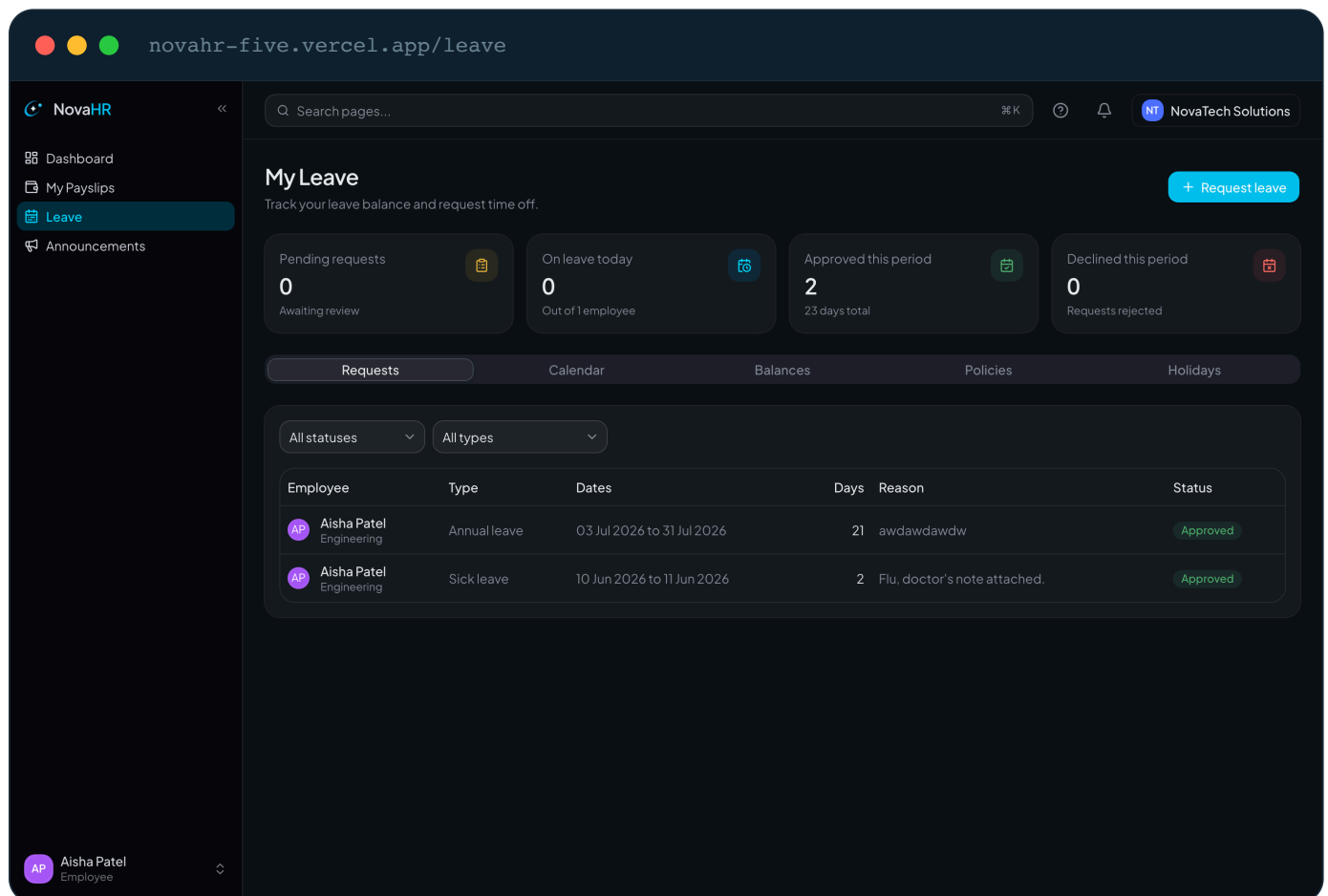


Figure 5.1: The employee leave page: request leave, and see your balances and history in one place.

Approve or decline (manager)

Managers see their team's requests under **Leave**. Approvals can route through more than one reviewer if your company requires it.

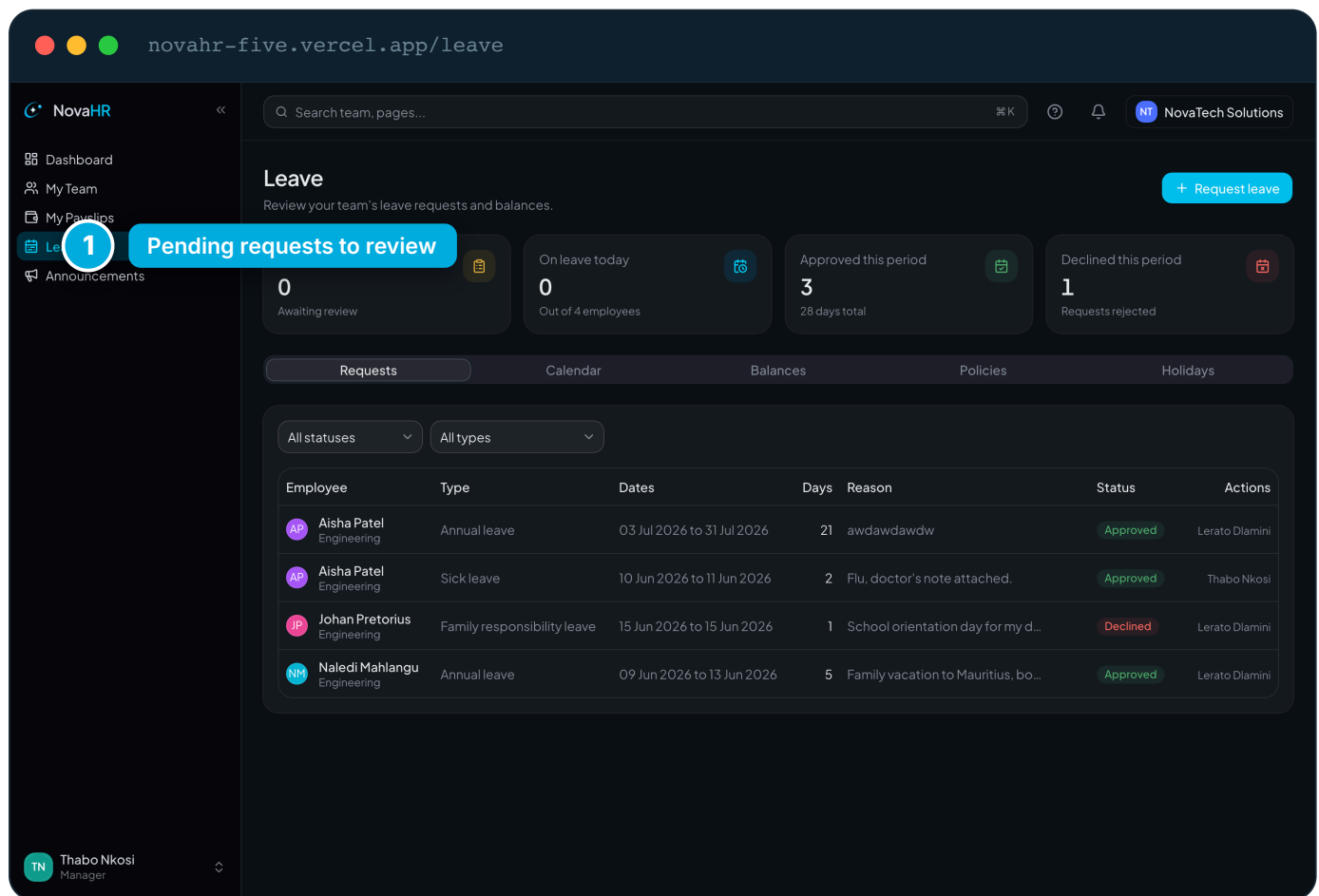


Figure 5.2: A manager reviewing their team's leave. Managers approve or decline their direct reports, never their own requests.

- Open a pending request, review the dates and balance, then **approve** or **decline** with an optional note.
- Employees can **cancel** a request they no longer need.
- A **leave calendar** and a **balances** table show who is away and how much each type they have left.

Leave encashment

HR can **pay out** unused annual leave mid-employment. The amount is added to the open pay run and the employee's balance is reduced automatically. On termination, leave can be encashed as part of final pay (section 9).

i Employer-paid family leave. Whether maternity, parental, adoption and commissioning leave are paid by you or claimed from UIF depends on the policy you set in section 2. The policy cards on the leave page always reflect your actual configuration.

6 Running payroll

A full South African PAYE engine with a clear run lifecycle: schedule, add variable pay, approve, complete, lock and publish.

HR administrator

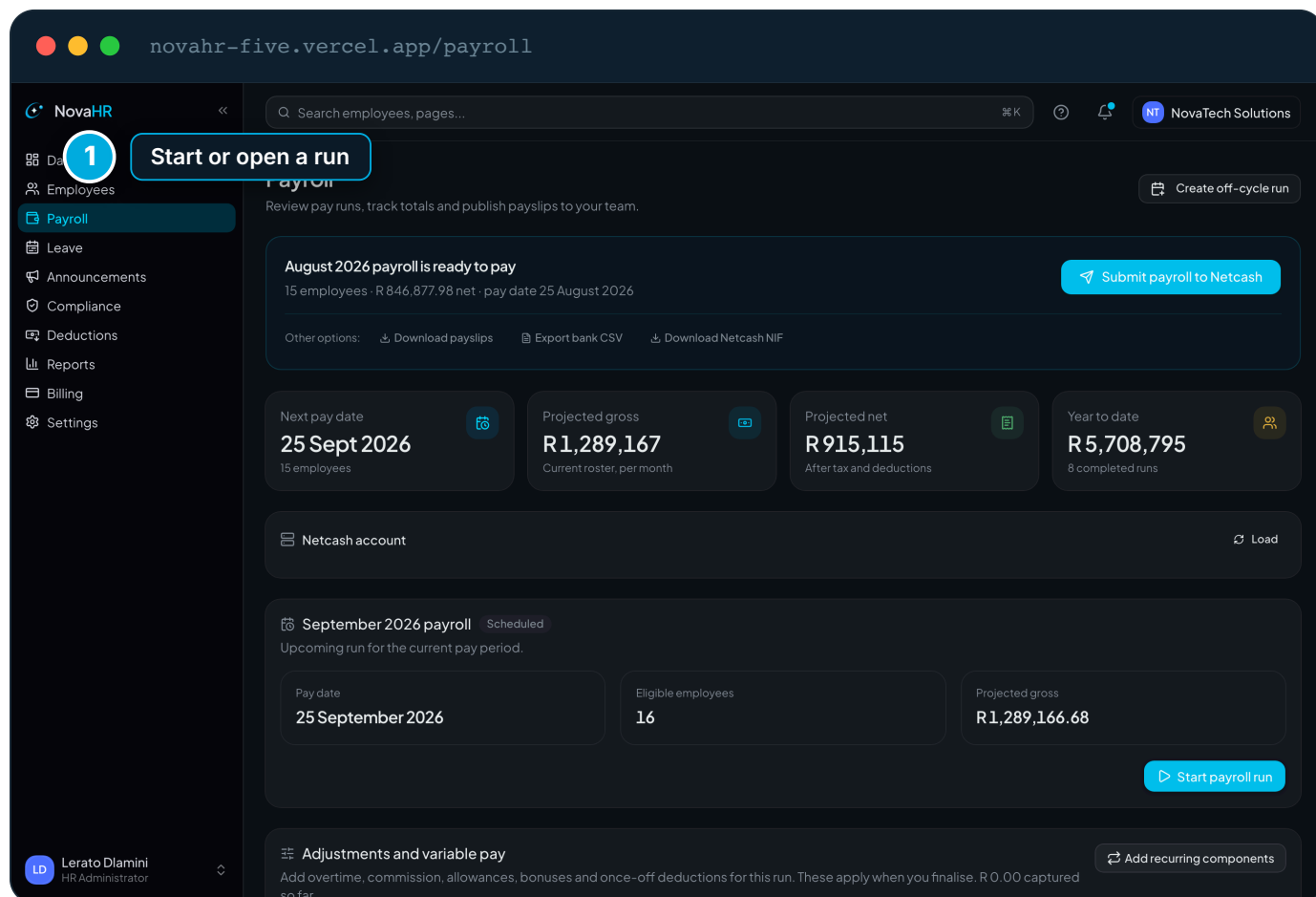


Figure 6.1: The payroll area. Schedule a run, then open it to add pay and process it.

The run lifecycle

- 1 Schedule & start.** A run is created for a pay period. Open it to begin. You can scope it to a **pay group** (a branch and/or a frequency) so weekly and monthly staff run separately.
- 2 Add variable pay.** On top of each person's regular pay, add overtime (1.5× or 2×), Sunday and public-holiday time, night-shift and standby allowances, commission, custom allowances, a bonus or thirteenth cheque, and any custom deductions. Import variable pay from a CSV template if you prefer.
- 3 Apply recurring items.** Recurring components you set on an employee (a standing allowance, for example) apply to the run in one click. Use the **back-pay** helper for arrears.
- 4 Approve.** Optionally route the run to an approver, who is notified by email.

Complete. NovaHR calculates PAYE (annualised, with rebates and age thresholds), the medical-aid credit, pension and retirement-annuity within the statutory cap, UIF and SDL.

Lock & publish. Lock the completed run, then publish payslips so employees can download them (section 7).

The screenshot shows the NovaHR payroll interface. On the left is a sidebar with navigation links: Dashboard, Employees, Payroll (selected), Leave, Announcements, Compliance, Deductions, Reports, Billing, and Settings. The main area displays a list of employees with their details and payroll calculations. Below the list is a 'Payroll register' section with an 'Export' button.

Employee number	Name	Branch	Gross	Basic	Allowances	Overtime	Commission	Bonus	PAYE	UIF
AP	Aisha Patel Senior Software Engineer	Engineering	R 79,166.67						-R 28,434.08	R 50,732.59
JP	Johan Pretorius Software Engineer	Engineering	R 54,166.67						-R 17,376.70	R 36,789.97
NM	Naledi Mahlangu DevOps Engineer	Engineering	R 65,000.00						-R 22,060.95	R 42,939.05
RG	Ryan Govender Head of Product	Product	R 116,666.67						-R 45,854.70	R 70,811.97
ZM	Zanele Mthembu Head of Design	Design	R 95,833.33						-R 36,191.16	R 59,642.17
CA	Craig Adams Head of Sales	Sales	R 131,000.00						-R 51,608.12	R 79,391.88
BK	Buhle Khumalo Account Executive	Sales	R 52,333.33						-R 16,148.70	R 36,184.63
MV	Michelle van Wyk Head of Marketing	Marketing	R 91,666.67						-R 34,298.45	R 57,368.22
WB	Werner Botha Finance Manager	Finance	R 75,000.00						-R 26,618.45	R 48,381.55
TS	Tumi Sithole Payroll Administrator	Finance	R 35,000.00						-R 9,747.12	R 25,252.88
KM	Kabelo Modise Head of Customer Success	Customer Success	R 87,500.00						-R 32,405.75	R 55,094.25
SW	Sarah Williams Customer Success Manager	Customer Success	R 43,333.33						-R 12,961.70	R 30,371.63
WM	Wandile Mtshwene Actuarial Applications Developer	Engineering	R 166,666.67						-R 65,743.20	R 100,923.47

Payroll register Export

Figure 6.2: Inside a pay run: every employee with gross, deductions and net, plus a payroll register you can export.

Off-cycle and corrections

- **Off-cycle runs** for a bonus or a correction finalise on their own, separately from the monthly run.
- A completed run can be **unlocked** and adjusted, or **reversed**, unless it is locked or already sent to the bank.
- **Leave encashment** and **unpaid-leave** deductions flow straight into pay.

Paying and reconciling

- **Bank export** for EFT, plus **Netcash** integration (validation, NIF file and batch submission).
- **GL journal export** and a **payroll register** in CSV or Excel for your accounting system.

⚠ Locking matters. Once a run is locked or submitted to the bank it cannot be cancelled or reversed. Reconcile before you lock.

7 Payslips & self-service

Publish payslips for the team, and let every employee manage their own details, documents and tax certificates.

HR administrator (publish)

Employee (self-service)

Publishing payslips

- After a run is completed, **publish payslips** to release them to employees.
- Download a single payslip or a **bulk ZIP** of every payslip in the run.
- Payslips carry your branding from the payslip studio (section 2).

What employees can do themselves

The screenshot displays the NovaHR employee self-service interface. The browser address bar shows `novahr-five.vercel.app/payroll`. The left sidebar contains navigation links: Dashboard, My Payslips (active), Leave, and Announcements. The main content area is titled "My Payslips" and includes a search bar. Below the title, there are four summary cards: "Latest net pay" (R 50,732.59 for August 2026), "Monthly gross" (R 79,166.67 for current salary), "Year to date" (R 389,463 for 8 payslips), and "Next pay date" (25 Sept 2026 for September 2026). A section for "Tax certificate (IRP5 / IT3(a))" for the year 2026/2027 is shown with a download button. Below this is a "Payslip history" table with columns for Period, Pay date, Gross, and Net, listing monthly data from January to August 2026. Each row has a "View" button. The bottom left corner shows the user profile for Aisha Patel, an Employee.

Period	Pay date	Gross	Net	Action
August 2026	25 Aug 2026	R 79,166.67	R 50,732.59	View
July 2026	25 Jul 2026	R 79,166.67	R 50,356.59	View
June 2026	25 Jun 2026	R 79,166.67	R 50,356.59	View
May 2026	25 May 2026	R 79,166.67	R 47,603.38	View
April 2026	25 Apr 2026	R 79,166.67	R 47,603.38	View
March 2026	25 Mar 2026	R 79,166.67	R 47,603.38	View
February 2026	25 Feb 2026	R 79,166.67	R 47,603.38	View
January 2026	25 Jan 2026	R 79,166.67	R 47,603.38	View

Figure 7.1: The employee view: download your own payslips and tax certificates without asking HR.

- **Payslips:** download any published payslip.
- **Tax certificates:** download their own IRP5 / IT3(a) once issued (section 10).
- **Profile:** keep contact details, address and banking up to date.

- **Documents:** view files HR has shared with them, with signed, private access.

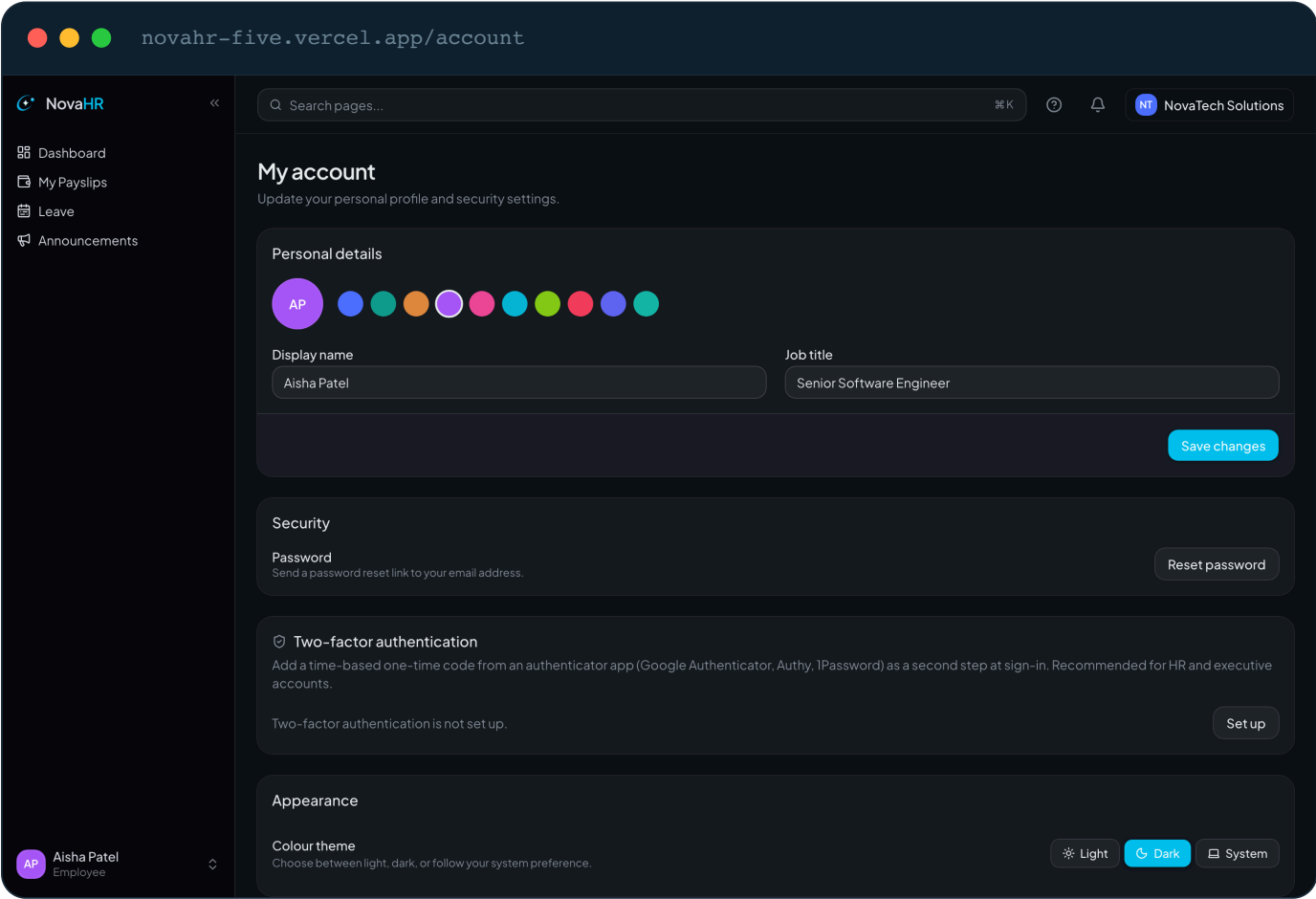


Figure 7.2: The employee account page, including two-factor authentication.

8 Deductions, loans & documents

Track money owed and recovered over time, and keep every employee document safe with version history.

HR administrator

Deductions and loans

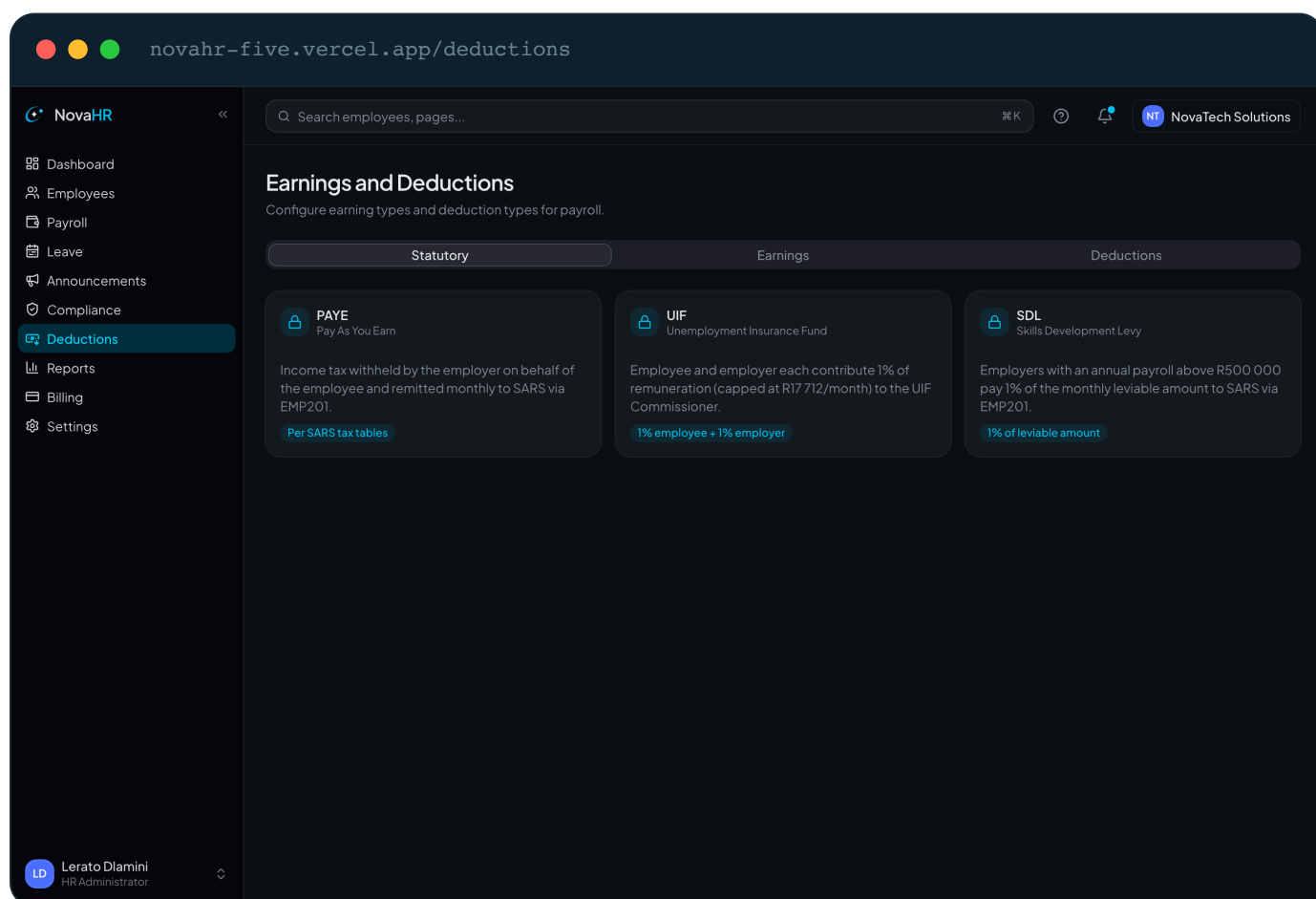


Figure 8.1: Employee deductions with recovery tracking.

- Record **loans and garnishees** and track how much has been recovered against each.
- Set up **recurring deductions** that apply automatically each run.
- Deductions flow into payroll (section 6) and appear on payslips.

The documents vault

- Upload files **per employee** with categories and expiry dates.
- Access is **private and signed**, so only the right people can open a document.
- **Version history**: re-uploading a file with the same name supersedes the old one but keeps every prior version.

i Generated letters. NovaHR can produce offer, confirmation, warning and termination letters for an employee. You will find these on the employee record and in the exit flow (section 9).

9 Performance, discipline & exits

Run reviews, keep disciplinary records, and handle terminations with the right paperwork and final pay.

HR administrator

Manager (own team)

Performance reviews

- Run a review **cycle** with a one-to-five rating, strengths, areas to improve and goals.
- Managers review only their **direct reports**; the employee can **acknowledge** the review.

Disciplinary records

Log warnings, counselling and hearings against an employee, each with an issue date and an expiry date, so records lapse at the right time.

Terminations and final pay

- 1 Start the **termination** flow on the employee record.
- 2 Capture the **termination and final-pay dates** and the reason.
- 3 Choose whether to **encash** outstanding leave on exit; it is added to the final pay.
- 4 Generate the **termination letter** and any other letters you need.

All of this is captured on the employee's history timeline, so you keep a complete record.

10 Statutory compliance

The South African statutory outputs you need through the year, from monthly declarations to year-end certificates.

HR administrator

The screenshot displays the NovaHR Compliance interface. The left sidebar contains navigation links: Dashboard, Employees, Payroll, Leave, Announcements, Compliance (selected), Deductions, Reports, Billing, and Settings. The main content area is titled 'Compliance' and includes a search bar, tabs for 'Monthly (EMP201)', 'Year-end (IRP5 / EMP501)', and 'Annual (COIDA)', and a 'Generate EMP201' button. Below this, three summary cards show 'PAYE Tax', 'UIF Return', and 'SDL Return', all with a value of 'R 0.00' and a note 'No record for Aug 2026'. A 'Compliance records' table lists four entries for July 2026, all marked as 'Overdue'.

Period	Type	Amount	Due Date	Status	Reference	Actions
Jul 2026	PAYE Return	R 310,850.65	07 Aug 2026	Overdue	-	Submit
Jul 2026	UIF Return	R 2,479.68	07 Aug 2026	Overdue	-	Submit
Jul 2026	SDL Return	R 11,808.33	07 Aug 2026	Overdue	-	Submit
Jul 2026	EMP201	R 325,138.66	07 Aug 2026	Overdue	-	Submit

Figure 10.1: The compliance area, with monthly and annual statutory outputs in one place.

OUTPUT	WHAT IT IS
EMP201	Monthly declaration of PAYE, UIF, SDL and ETI, with an on-screen panel and export.
EMP501	Year-end reconciliation of what was declared against what was certified.
IRP5 / IT3(a)	Employee tax certificates: bulk PDF or ZIP for HR, and self-service download for each employee.
ETI	Employment Tax Incentive calculation and claim schedule.
UIF	UIF declaration export.
COIDA	Return of Earnings (W.As.8): actual versus assessable earnings per employee, with totals, in CSV or Excel.
Employment Equity	EEA2 workforce profile and EEA4 income differentials as on-screen tables and a statutory-style PDF.
POPIA	Data-subject handling helpers and the legal pages that back your privacy obligations.

 **Verify before filing.** COIDA and Employment Equity outputs carry a reminder to check them against the current Department of Labour or Compensation Fund form before you submit. NovaHR prepares the numbers; you confirm them against the live form.

11 Reports & analytics

See the shape of your workforce and your payroll at a glance, and export the detail when you need it.

HR administrator

Executive (read-only)

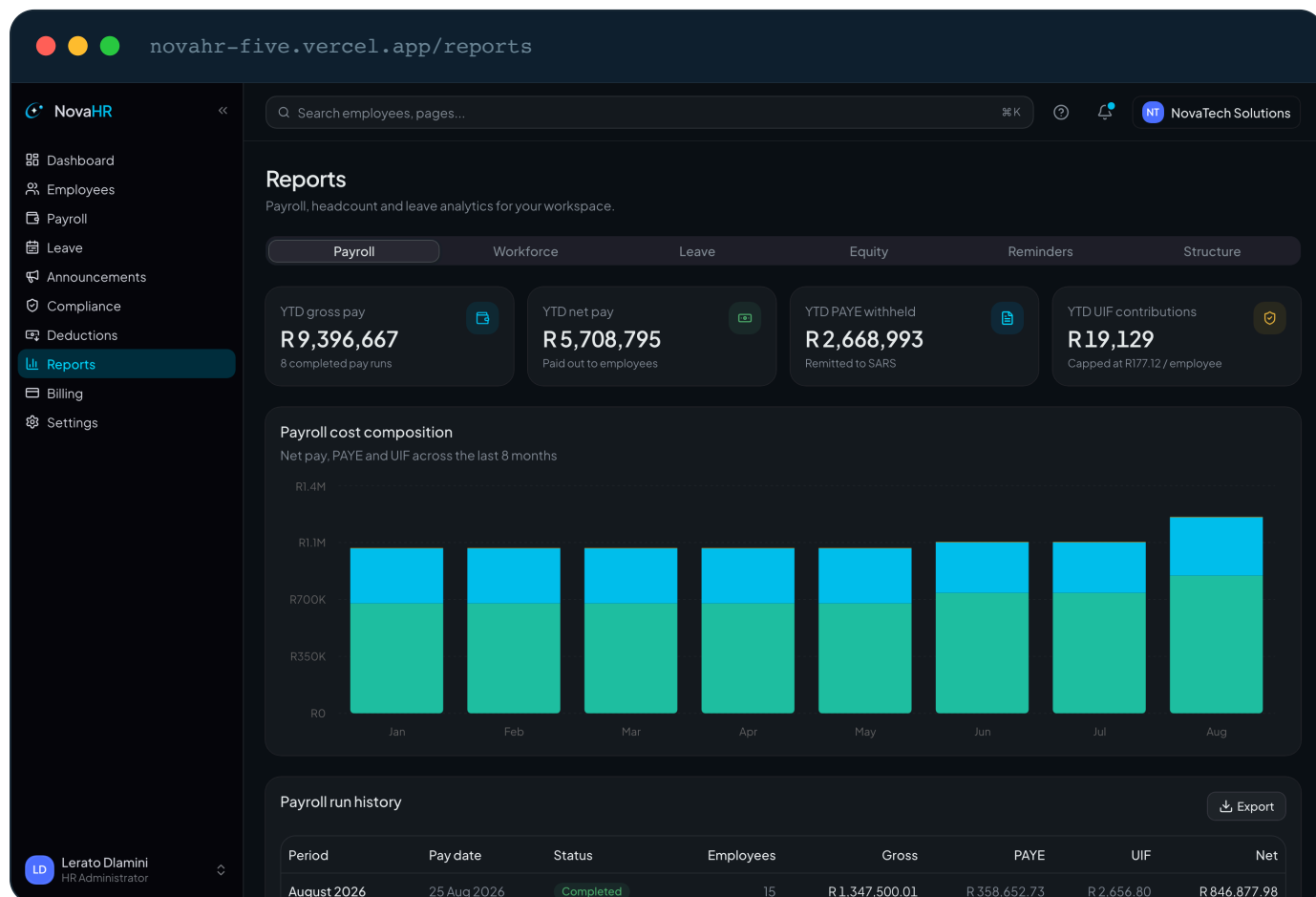


Figure 11.1: The reports area with payroll, workforce, leave and equity views.

REPORT	SHOWS
Payroll	Year-to-date gross, net, PAYE and UIF, run history and a composition chart.
Workforce	Headcount, department cost, budget utilisation and employment-mix charts.
Leave	Utilisation by leave type.
Equity	EEA2 and EEA4 tables with a PDF export.

12 Users, roles & billing

Invite your team, manage who can do what, work across multiple companies, and handle your subscription.

HR administrator

Inviting and managing users

- 1 Invite people by email, one at a time or **in bulk** from the employee list.
- 2 Each invite is a one-time secure link, delivered by email with a copyable fallback link. You can **resend** or **revoke** it.
- 3 Change a person's **role** or remove their access at any time.
- 4 For larger companies, create a **branch-scoped admin**: an HR user limited to a single branch.

i Multi-company. One account can belong to several workspaces. Inviting an existing account simply grants it access to your company. Removing a person only deletes their account if it was their last workspace.

Billing and subscription

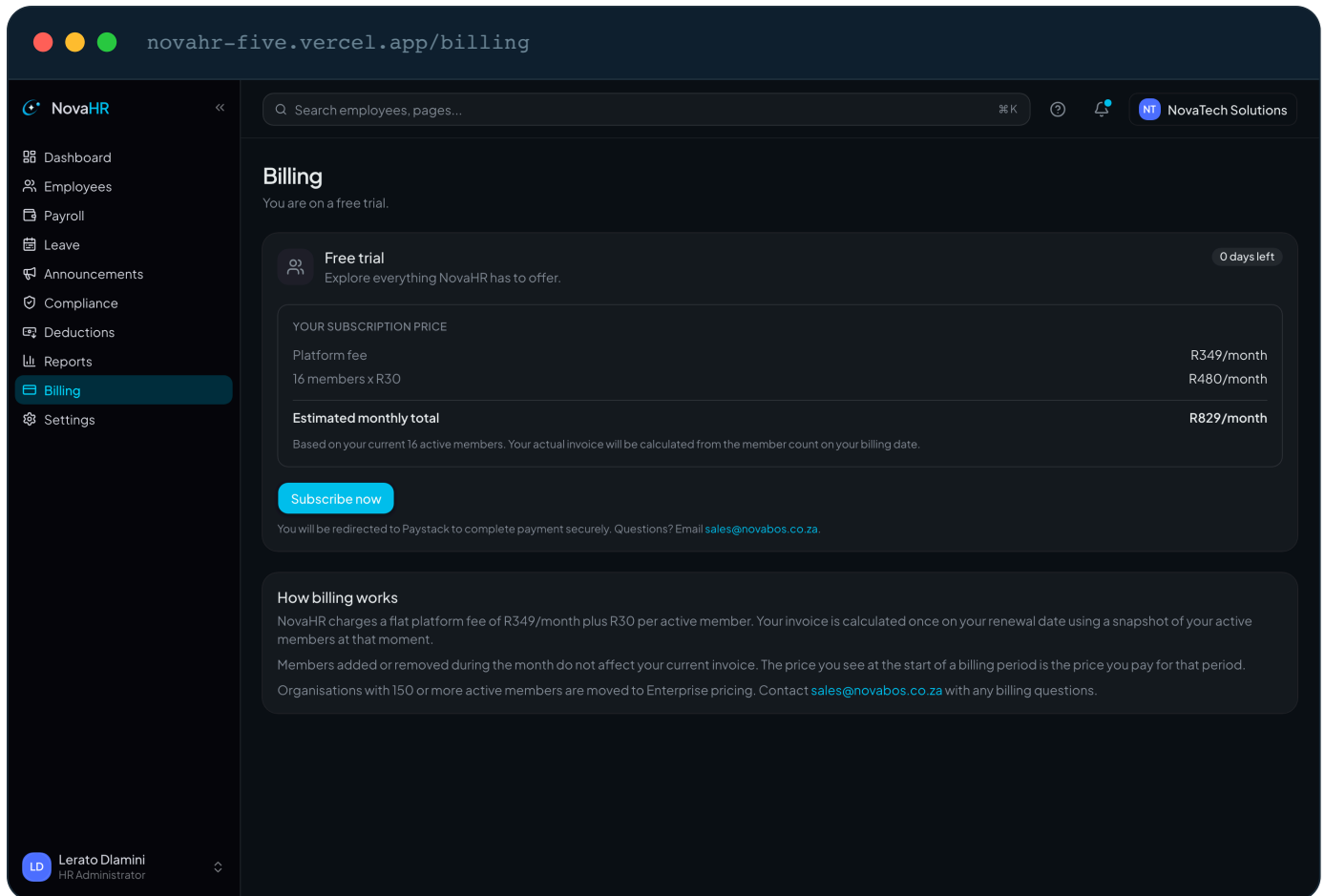


Figure 12.1: Billing: choose a plan and manage your subscription through Paystack.

- Start on a **free trial**, then choose a plan when you are ready.
- Payments are handled securely through **Paystack**.
- Manage your plan and see your billing status from the **Billing** page.

i That is the whole product. For a one-page summary of every capability and the current limitations, see the [Capabilities & limitations](#) sheet. Need a hand? Contact your NovaHR administrator or support.